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The Wrong Cheering Section

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The Wrong Cheering Section

When the righteous prosper, the city rejoices; when the wicked perish, there are shouts of joy. (Proverbs 11:10)

A wise man fears the Lord and shuns evil, but a fool is hot-headed and reckless. A quick-tempered man does foolish things, and a crafty man is hated. (Proverbs 14:16- 17)

Most people give little thought to the response of the populace at their death. For most, it's a wake, a memorial service, a public obituary, some public grieving, a respectful burial, and a marker stone in a cemetery.

Prominent people—especially politically powerful ones—leave a more significant mark on society and history. Such is the case with Herod the Great (37 - 4 BC). A violent and paranoid king, Herod appears in the account of Jesus' birth in Bethlehem (Matthew 2) and is the man credited with commanding the slaughter of all male children under two years of age in his realm...in a failed attempt to destroy the reported "King of the Jews—Jesus." Herod killed one of his ten wives, two of her sons, her brother, her grandfather, her mother, three of his fourteen children, and assorted other enemies and "friends." He tried desperately to kill Jesus. Imagine the number of people thrilled to have King Herod gone!

Anticipating the public rejoicing at his death, King Herod selected well-loved public figures and ordered that they be called to the capitol at his death and murdered...so the grief from their murders would drown out the rejoicing over his death. Thankfully, his son and his sister refused to carry out the order.

There were shouts of joy at the news of Herod's passing. For good reason!

Principle: At your death, you have a choice—people cheering your character or cheering your departure. Only you can decide.

Solomon and his associates explain how you end up being hated. It isn't that hard, really. Rephrasing Proverbs 14:16-17 above, (1) you act a fool, (2) let your anger run out of control, and (3) be cunning and conniving. That ought to do it! It worked for King Herod.

Principle: The easiest way to draw contempt from others is to sow contemptible motives and behaviors in your dealings with them; sow grace and kindness, and you will usually reap grace and kindness.

Proverbs 12:25 suggests that “an anxious heart weighs a man down, but a kind word cheers him up.”

I was once on the studio lot at Sony/Columbia Pictures waiting for the tram which operates around the spacious studio. As I waited, I observed a man in a work uniform with a broom and a scoop picking up gum wrappers, cigarette butts, and other refuse.

“Sir,” I said, “I want to thank you for your work. Watching you, I was thinking what a mess this lot would be if you were not doing what you are doing. You are very important here.”

At first, it was as if he was not sure I was talking to him. Then, he straightened up, looked me in the eye, and told me that he was the third generation of his family “in show business.” As I boarded the tram, he pursued the litter with his shoulders up and a smile on his countenance. It appeared that one kind comment and a listening ear had made his day!

Principle: One never knows how large a lever a kind word is to lift a sagging spirit and offload a heavy burden.

Kindness can cause a city to rejoice! If only Herod had known.

[from “*Wisdom for the Trenches*” by Dr. Larry W. Poland]